

northandwestlinksedited

Travel Radio Australia and we continue our series on Ireland and we're here with Dave Wensley who is the Managing Director of North and West Coast Links Golf Ireland. Now North and West Coast Links Golf is a great company that can help you to do a whole golfing holiday around the beautiful Green Isle. Dave, welcome to the program.

Geoff, thank you very much. Great to be here at the IGTM representing the company North and West Coast Links. Yes, tell us what you do.

You do tours and all that sort of thing around Ireland. Yeah, yeah. So our company has been in existence for over 35 years.

We've been welcoming guests from all over the world. Many, many Australian visitors come to Ireland to play golf and we've been doing this for the last kind of 30 years. So we're kind of well-versed at the moment in what we're doing, you know.

Tell us where you're based and I suppose you fan out from there to the whole country. Yeah, so our company is actually based in Galway which is on the very west coast of Ireland. Galway wouldn't be the best for golf.

You know, a lot of people come to Ireland for golf. They tend to land in Dublin and travel north and normally have a couple of days in Galway at the end, particularly the Australian groups because of the proximity because it takes so long to get there. When they come in, they like to come in for two or three weeks and really make the most of all the different cities and the golf courses.

Like a typical tour for an Australian coming into Ireland would be land in Dublin, spend a couple of nights in Dublin, kind of get on the bus. So we, you know, we work with lots of luxury transport providers. You have the leather seats, you have the coolers for the beer, you've got the tables so they can have a game of cards and then drive up north to maybe stay in a city like Derry, have a game of golf on the way maybe in County Louth which is kind of directly en route and stay in a city like Derry for kind of five nights where you can access Royal Portrush, Port Stewart, Castle Rock, Ballyliffin, all within an hour drive.

A few nights in Derry, enjoy the crack, enjoy the Guinness, enjoy the great Irish food they have to offer. A little bit of, you know, we always recommend groups have a couple of days off, maybe two or three rounds of golf, then a day or two off. Really get to experience the local culture, get to experience some tours.

We do a lot of whiskey tasting, a lot of distillery tours, castle tours, really experience the culture, go out to the local bars, go out to the local restaurants, enjoy some of the fresh fish we have to offer. So normally two or three rounds of golf with a couple of days off in between and then from

Derry, you know, head kind of south, head towards Ballinar, stay in a castle like Mount Falcon and then you've got some great golf courses on the way down like Strand Hill, you have Enniskrone, Cairn. Stay there for a few nights, again get to experience some of the local culture in the west of Ireland and then spend maybe a few nights in Galway, play golf courses like Connemara, Galway Bay Golf Resort, have a bit of fun and then back to Dublin where you're pretty pretty exhausted after a long trip.

Now the company itself, North and West Coast Links Golf Ireland, did you start it yourself? What's the history of the company? Oh well it's an interesting one. John McLaughlin is the founder and the CEO of North and West Coast Links. So John used to be a manager of Connemara Golf Links out in the west of Ireland and I suppose they were finding a lot of the traffic coming into Ireland to play golf was predominantly going into the southwest where you got great golf courses like Ballybunion, Tralee, Le Hinch, you know that's where the kind of well-traveled golf was going.

So John who was manager of Connemara got together with the general manager from County Sligo, Enniskrone and Cairn and they formed what was called the West Coast Links. So what they did is they all put a bit of money together and started marketing at different events like the one we're at now, the IGTM, and they went out on the road, met tour operators, go to a lot of consumer events to meet guys just to kind of just to say look the product we have in the west coast is equally as good as the product in the southwest, it's just people aren't traveling. So they got together, spent a bit of money, met a lot of tour operators and then the tour operators would often say to them look well can you just book it for us.

So then the company really evolved to become like a DMC and a tour operator and then because of the success of golf in the west of Ireland it kind of grew to the northwest where you know courses like Ballyliffin, Castle Rock, Port Stewart, Port Rush all joined the company and said look start promoting our region as well. So that's where we're now North and West Coast Links and that's where we're at. A large part of our business, we attend about 32 different events every year pushing our brochure, our golf courses and our hotels in the region but we're also a tour operator and a DMC so we welcome people from all over the world, we put the chips together for them, we've been in the business so long, we know every pub, we know every restaurant, we know the best restaurants, the best tours, we use great coach, all the coach drivers are fantastic.

You've got a group 8 or 12 guys coming over, we'd always recommend getting the bus and the driver, you don't have to worry about driving in the morning after a few drinks, you don't have to worry about all that sort of thing but we also do self-drivers, there's a group of two or a group of four that wanted to come over, we've a great contract with Hertz, 8 and 12 guys, the couple's coming over as well, we tend to look after them with a coach and driver for the whole experience and it just elevates the experience and makes the most of the whole trip. Now County Kerry is such a beautiful part of Ireland isn't it and you're from there and can you give us a few recommendations personally where people should, if they're heading into Kerry, what they should

go and see apart from playing great golf, there's so much else there isn't it? Kerry is a beautiful, you know, absolutely beautiful county, you know, there's lots of peninsulas you can go down and investigate, you have the Ring of Kerry which is beautiful to go and see, if you go down to the Barrow Peninsula, you've got places like Kenmare and Castletown Bear, Kinsale, where the old head of Kinsale is, it's just a super town with some of the best fresh fish you've ever tasted, there's a distillery down in Cork, the Middleton distillery, which we'd highly recommend, you do a tour, tour the facility and get a whisky tasting, but to be honest there's all these sort of places, not just in Kerry but they're all over Ireland and some of the distilleries we have in Donegal, like the Sleave League distillery, you get to see the Sleave League Cliffs in Donegal, which is three times the height of the Cliffs of Moher, just doesn't get as many visitors but it's absolutely world-class, you go from there 20 minutes up the road to a distillery in Ardra, where you do the whisky tasting, go and see some Trina, which is like a woollen mill, get to see the mill being produced, there's so much to do all over Ireland, not just Kerry but all over Ireland, we strongly recommend coming over, playing a bit of golf, but having those days off to really experience what else we've got to offer. Did you grow up golfing yourself or you just got a taste for it when you were young? Yeah, I started playing golf, my mum was secretary of the local golf club so I got to go out quite a bit, I used to travel with her in the morning, went during the holidays, go out with a couple of lads and we used to play golf a lot of the time, just play golf all day, 36 holes back in the day when you're a kid, seems like nothing, I'm not sure I could manage it now, but I love golf from a young age and people always say you shouldn't work at your hobby, but I think that's wrong and I absolutely love this job, I love bringing people into Ireland, I love welcoming people to our shores where they get to experience the Lynx courses, a third of the world's Lynx courses are in Ireland, so people are just blown away when they see it and when they play it, if you're playing a shot maybe 165 yards in, you've got an 8-iron, when you see that ball land on the green and you see a splash of sand, you know you're on a real Lynx course and we love it and people come over and they're on holiday, they're all having a good time, everyone loves it, you might get to experience four seasons in one day, but that's all part of it, it's a great place to come and play golf.

The coastline and the weather, it all adds together for a fantastic experience isn't it and it's so changeable, one day it can be really moody and the next day brilliant sun. That's it and that's why the Lynx grass is so good, it's so strong and people always say the country's so green, it's because we do have that very small amount of rain that tends to encourage growth and that's what makes the golf so good Geoff. Now Dave Wensley, Managing Director of North and West Coast Lynx Golf Island, you can handle all of your fantastic golf trips around the Emerald Island, how can people find out more about your company Dave online? Yes, if you just look at northandwestcoastlynx.com, you can head on there, see a couple of the packages we have, you can see the team, all the email address and contact details are on it, just give our company a follow on social, we're quite active, we have a brilliant guy doing our social media, so just you can find us on Facebook or Twitter or Instagram, North and West Coast Lynx, look us up and you'll see some of our videos and it'll give you a taste of what to expect if you want to come over and

get a trip.

It really is great value, a lot of people seem to think golf's expensive in Ireland but it really, really isn't. If somebody comes to me with a budget, I will work out the perfect trip on that budget, I really will and you'll be looked after from the second you land in Ireland to the second you depart. I always encourage people to have a look at our reviews, go on North and West Coast Lynx to business and just look at our Google reviews and that'll give you a taste of what to expect when you come to Ireland.

Brilliant, well dios meri gud as they say in Gaelic and thank you very much for being on part of the programme and Travel Radio Australia. Do you speak a bit of Gaelic yourself? My wife's actually a lecturer at the University of Galway in Irish, so I should have a little bit more than I do but I have a couple of focalisms. Maybe you can say something in Gaelic for our Australian listeners out there.

I would say go raibh míle maith agath and we look forward to giving you a big falsher when you arrive in Ireland. Thanks Dave for being part of the programme. Geoff, you're very welcome, thank you very much.